



FREE TEMPLATE • INDIE MUSIC INDIA

Set List Creating Guide

How to build a set list that works for Indian live audiences, venue formats, and festival slots, from intimate club shows to large festival stages.

Part 1: Why The Set List Matters

A set list is not just a song order. It is a pacing document, a crowd management tool, and a statement of artistic intent. In the Indian live music circuit, where audiences range from seasoned gig-goers in Bengaluru's Humming Tree to first-time concert attendees at a college festival in Tier-2 cities, the set list is often the difference between a crowd that buys merch and tells their friends, and a crowd that checks their phones by song three.

A well-constructed set: _____

- Opens with something that captures attention immediately
 - Builds energy in a deliberate arc
 - Gives the crowd breathing room at the right moments
 - Ends with a moment people talk about on the walk out
-

Part 2: Know Your Context Before Building

Before writing a single song title, answer these questions:

1. Venue Type

- Club / Bar (50-300 capacity): Antisocial Delhi/Mumbai, Auro Bar, High Spirits Pune, Foxtrot Bengaluru
→ Intimacy is the asset. Banter and slower songs can work. Crowd is usually there specifically for you.
- Mid-size venue (300-1000): Humming Tree, IISC Open Air Theatre
→ Balance energy with artistry. These crowds expect a full show, not just a DJ playlist with a live band.
- Festival stage (1000+): NH7 Weekender, Magnetic Fields, Ziro Festival, Boxout Weekender, Vh1 Supersonic
→ You may have 30-45 minutes and a large portion of the crowd who don't know your songs. Open strong and close stronger.

2. Slot Position

- Opening Act: Keep it tight and high energy. You have 20-30 minutes to make a new audience care about you.
- Middle of Bill: You have more room. Build a proper arc.
- Headliner: You can afford dynamic contrast, quiet moments, a song story, a fan moment.

3. Time Of Day

- Afternoon festival slots (3-5 PM): Crowd is sober and exploratory. Polished performances win over raw energy.
- Evening prime time (8-10 PM): Peak energy window. Your best songs go here.
- Late night (post 11 PM): Crowd may be tired or very drunk. Keep tempos up or go very intimate, no in-between.

4. Audience Familiarity

- Home city crowd: Will sing along. Reward them with deep cuts.
- New city crowd: Lead with your most accessible, hook-heavy songs.
- Festival crowd (mixed): Assume most people don't know you. Make every song feel like the best song you've ever written.

5. Set Length

- 20 minutes: 4-5 songs
- 30 minutes: 6-7 songs
- 45 minutes: 8-10 songs
- 60 minutes: 11-13 songs
- 75-90 minutes (headline): 14-18 songs with possible encore

Part 3: The Set List Arc

Think of your set as having four

phases: _____

PHASE 1, THE HOOK (First 2 songs) Your strongest, most immediate songs. High energy or arresting and distinctive. The crowd is still forming an opinion. Give them no reason to disengage.

PHASE 2, THE BUILD (Middle third) You have earned some goodwill. Now show range. A slower song that reveals depth, a fan favourite, a new song sandwiched between two known quantities so the crowd gives it a chance.

PHASE 3, THE CLIMAX (Last 3 songs before encore) Your best crowd moments. A sing-along, a high-tempo release, a song that has a specific live moment, a breakdown, a key change, an audience call-and-response.

Phase 4, The Closer / Encore

The song people hum on the drive home. If you have one song people know above all others, this is where it goes. If you're new enough that no song is widely known, make this your most emotionally complete performance.

Part 4: Practical Set List Template

Show: _____ Venue: _____

_____ City: _____

_____ Date: _____

_____ Set Length: _____

Estimated BPM range for set: _____

#	Song Title	BPM	Key	Duration	Energy (1-5)	Notes / Cues
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						
10						

	ENCORE					
E1						
E2						

Total Set Time: _____

Part 5: Common Mistakes To Avoid

1. Opening with a new song nobody knows, even if you're proud of it, an opener needs to grab people who are still finding their spots. 2. Putting three slow songs in a row, breaks momentum completely in a live setting. 3. Ignoring the soundcheck set list, practise the actual set in soundcheck order once. Technical glitches in song 1 are catastrophic. 4. No banter

preparation, you don't need a script, but know what you'll say between songs 2 and 3, and between songs 6 and 7. Dead air is harder to recover from in India where audiences are vocal. 5. Playing past your slot time, in India, festival schedules often run late. Going over your allotted time is seen as disrespectful to other artists and to the organiser. Always have a "cut version" of the set that drops 2 songs. 6. Forgetting the sound engineer, your FOH engineer needs the set list too, ideally with notes on any unusual cues (intro tape, key change cue, abrupt ending).

Part 6: Set List Logistics

Copies needed: _____

- One for each band member (taped to floor monitor or music stand)
- One for sound engineer (FOH desk)
- One for monitor engineer (if separate)
- One for tour manager / stage manager
- One for lighting operator (if applicable)
- One for yourself as artist

Format: Large font (18pt minimum), printed, not handwritten. In low-light conditions, printed set lists on white paper are non-negotiable.

Tape: Use gaffer tape to fix to floor. Always keep a spare printed copy in your gig bag.

Digital option: Setlist.fm allows you to log and archive set lists. Useful for tracking what works across different cities and audiences.

Part 7: Post-Show Set List Review

After every show, note: _____

- Which song got the best crowd response and why
- Which song felt flat and why (energy issue, technical issue, wrong placement)
- What you'd move, cut, or add
- Any spontaneous moments that worked and should be built into future shows

Keep a master log of this feedback. After 10 shows, clear patterns will tell you which songs are genuinely working live versus which ones you love in the studio but aren't translating on stage.

Created by: _____

Date: _____

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